

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

3 allies recognize state of Palestine

Israel angry about declaration by UK, Canada, Australia

By Pan Pylas
Associated Press

LONDON — The U.K., Australia and Canada formally recognized a Palestinian state on Sunday, prompting an angry response from Israel, which ruled out the prospect.

The coordinated initiative from the three Commonwealth nations and longtime allies reflects growing outrage at Israel's conduct of the war in Gaza and the steps taken by the Israeli government to thwart efforts to create a Palestinian state, including by the continued expansion of settlements in the West Bank.

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer, who has faced pressure within his own governing Labour Party to take a harder line on Israel over the deteriorating situation in Gaza, said the U.K.'s move is intended "to revive the hope of peace for the Palestinians and Israelis." He insisted it wasn't a reward for Hamas, which was behind the attack on Oct. 7, 2023, in which the militants killed 1,200 people and abducted 251.

"Today, to revive the hope of peace and a two-state solution, I state clearly as prime minister of this great country that the United Kingdom formally recognizes the state of Palestine," Starmer said in a video message. "We recognized the state of Israel more than 75 years ago as a homeland for the Jewish people. Today we join over 150 countries who recognize a Palestinian state also."

The moves by the three countries prompted Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahuh

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Speaking event stirs conflict in Geneva

Oath Keepers' founder convicted in Jan. 6 riot to speak to GOP-tied group

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Amid outrage following the assassination of Chicago-area native and conservative activist Charlie Kirk and fears of escalating violence across the political spectrum, a far west suburban group led by an Illinois Republican Party official is pressing ahead with an event featuring the founder of a right-wing extremist group who played a key role in the U.S. Capitol insurrection.

Even before Kirk was killed Sept. 10, Oath Keepers founder Stewart Rhodes' scheduled appearance on Tuesday in suburban Geneva was moved to a private location after local progressive groups protested giving a platform to a man whose 18-year prison sentence for seditious conspiracy was commuted when President Donald Trump on the first day of his second term issued a sweeping clemency order for the nearly 1,600 people charged in the Jan. 6, 2021, riot.

Rhodes' event is part of a series of talks, titled "Pints

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The sun sets on Brooklyn, Illinois, as two people bike through town in November 2024. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

Setbacks, hope stand for nation's oldest Black town

Community leaders in Brooklyn, Illinois, are fighting for its legacy and survival

By Jonathan Bullington
Chicago Tribune

BROOKLYN, Ill. — The brick building at Madison and South 5th streets is still vacant, still boarded up, still tagged with faded gang graffiti.

For the second time in as many years, it's been slated for a \$2.5 million makeover, courtesy of the federal government, that would transform the building — once a grocery store and, later, a skating rink — into a community center for this historic town of 650 people across the Mississippi River from St. Louis.

And once again, the project has stalled, its future uncertain, amid partisan spending battles in Washington, D.C., and the looming threat of a government shutdown.

"This is a good example of an important community project being held hostage," said U.S. Rep. Nikki Budzinski, a Springfield Democrat whose district covers Brooklyn and who included the community center as part of her



The newly installed Freedom Village and Priscilla "Mother" Baltimore monument on the north side of Brooklyn.

federal appropriations requests in fiscal years 2025 and 2026.

"These communities, and Brooklyn is a great example, are not flush with cash," she added. "They're in need of these federal investments (and) the level of uncertainty is creating anxiety."

There have been plenty of reasons for anxiety, and some signs of hope, in Brooklyn this year as community members and supporters fight to stave off the city's demise and preserve its legacy as America's oldest Black town.

In January, the Chicago Tribune profiled Brooklyn: Its founding in the early 1830s as a refuge for free and enslaved Black people. Its days as a thriving entertainment hub. Its eventual decline in the second half of the 20th century and the disparate group of archaeologists, urban planners, preservationists, current residents and former Brooklynites at the center of an ambitious revitalization plan.

Shortly after the story published, staff from U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin's office contacted Brooklyn officials to offer federal help. People familiar with those discussions said they included the possible construction of a dual visitor center and museum, but excitement for the plan had been quashed a few months later when it became clear that President Donald Trump's administration had little appetite for anything that spoke to the country's history of racism.

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INSIDE



DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Hundreds race in Chicago River Swim

For the first time in nearly a century, swimmers jumped into the river for an official race, raising \$100,000 for ALS research. Above: Erin Randall swims near Dearborn Street. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Kirk praised at memorial service

President Donald Trump and members of his Make America Great Again movement paid tribute to the slain activist Sunday. **Nation & World**

Bears get first win under Johnson

The Bears offense woke up Sunday against a reeling Cowboys defense, and the 31-14 win was the first with coach Ben Johnson. **Chicago Sports**

'This guy was scary'

Ex-Chicago vice cop, Outfit hitman Mandell dies in prison

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

For much of his life, death seemed to follow Steve Mandell.

In his early days, Mandell was, of all things, a Chicago vice cop. After being kicked off the force for insurance fraud, he used his police training to become a prolific robber, extortionist, drug dealer and, according to state and federal law enforcement, a cold-blooded killer.

Over time, the bodies piled up: A suspected informant executed in his car at a downtown intersection. Mandell's own father, found hogtied and shot in a trunk. A trucking firm owner fished out of the Des Plaines River days after telling his wife he was going to meet Mandell and never came back.

And then there was the case that landed Mandell in prison

for life: a macabre plot foiled by the FBI in 2012 to kidnap and extort wealthy businessmen, then torture and dismember them in his own, custom-built killing chamber.

Last week, after spending a decade in one of the country's highest-security prisons, Mandell died of an undisclosed illness at a federal medical prison facility in North Carolina, according to the U.S. Bureau of Prisons. He was 74.

While never one of Chicago's more high-profile mob figures, Mandell, who once went by the name Steven Manning, has a story that's unique even in the city's heavily chronicled underworld. Not only was he the first former law enforcement officer to ever be sentenced to Illinois' Death Row, he later became a celebrated exoneree and won a landmark \$6.5 million judgment against the FBI for framing him — only to have the judge reverse the jury's award.

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